



Not over yet: "I'm an eternal optimist. I will get back to chess in the future and try to reach that rating to become a GM," says S. Vijayalakshmi, India's first Woman Grandmaster. PICS: SIVASANKAR. A

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The uncertain life of a GM

There are still adequate opportunities, at least for GMs in India, to make a **steady living** from the game. But the rate at which we are producing GMs might soon eclipse the demand.

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Long before S. Vijayalakshmi began teaching students through a laptop, she learnt the trade by cutting out the chess game published each day in *The Hindu* and pasting it into a notebook. Chess books were scarce and expensive, while computers belonged to a distant future. In 1997, *Sportstar* sponsored her first laptop. **Nearly three decades later, technology lies at the heart of her second innings in the sport.**

Her transition from player to coach carries particular poignancy because of how close she came to the open Grandmaster (GM) title. The first Indian woman to become a